committed to environmental investment. These could not be stopped. Faced with this situation, Ratan reached out to the British government for assistance on this as well as on Corus.

He met British Prime Minister Gordon Brown and Secretary of State for Business Lord Peter Mandelson in November 2008. He followed up the visit with a letter to the secretary the next day, appealing to him to ‘find a meaningful solution to enable JLR to tide over its financial crunch’.

The financial crisis, however, only got worse. In the following month he again addressed Lord Mandelson seeking ‘immediate bridge liquidity support at commercial terms for either £500 million of direct funding or state guarantees’ to enable JLR to make commercial borrowings. He added that the support would be required for two years. Besides, he would need state guarantees for the European Investment Bank (EIB) to lend Tata Motors an amount beyond €200 million. Ratan also reassured Mandelson that the Tatas ‘firmly believe that JLR is a viable business with a strong future’.

Ratan underscored that ‘further restructuring actions’ would be absolutely ‘necessary to reduce the cost base in 2009’. He explained to Lord Mandelson that he was making the request due to the extraordinary circumstances. He added that the group had ‘never sought financial assistance from the government before’ and it was being done now ‘only because of the extraordinarily difficult global liquidity situation’.

The British government was nonchalant. In the third week of December, the deputy high commissioner of the UK to India called Ratan to say that Lord Mandelson was indisposed and had deputed Brian Bender of the Department for Business, Enterprise and Regulatory Reform (BERR) to speak to him. Bender called to tell Ratan that Mark Russell, adviser to BERR, would like a ‘face-to-face meeting’ or video conferencing with senior executives of Tata Sons to ascertain if ‘all avenues of supporting JLR from within the Tata Group’ had been exhausted.

The request was a direct attack on Ratan’s integrity. It was tantamount to questioning his motives, especially as he had conveyed to the British government that the request had been made only after he had explored all other avenues. Ratan was visibly hurt by the imputation. He also lamented that Russell’s request to ascertain if the group had exhausted other means of finance ‘went beyond the bounds of appropriateness’.